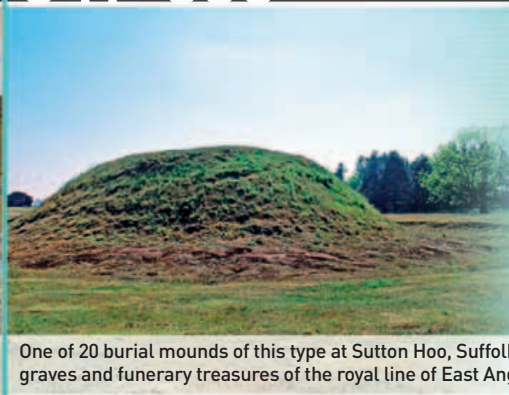




One of 20 burial mounds of this type at Sutton Hoo, Suffolk, England, which conceal the graves and funerary treasures of the royal line of East Anglia.

“THEY BEQUEATHED THE GLEAMING GOLD, TREASURE OF MEN, TO EARTH.”

From the Old English epic poem, *Beowulf*

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OF THE SUTTON
HOO SHIP

unchecked even by the assassination in 644 of Umar by a Persian slave. His successor, **Uthman**, promulgated the **first written version of the Qu'ran**, which had previously been transmitted orally.

After launching successful expeditions against the Tibetans and Mongolians, but failing to conquer Korea, the **Tang emperor Taizong** (r. 626–49) died in 649, and his weak-willed son began to cede increasing influence to the **Empress Wu** (624–705). In Japan, the **Fujiwara** clan enacted the **Taika reforms** in 646, bringing all land into imperial ownership and centralizing power following the Chinese model.

In **England**, Christian converts battled pagan kings for control over territory and the religious and cultural direction of the

Sutton Hoo helmet

This reconstruction is made from iron with highly decorated panels of tinned bronze.

region. In 642, for instance, the Christian king **Oswald of Northumbria**, hitherto one of the most powerful kingdoms, was slain by the pagan king **Penda of Mercia**. The great Anglo-Saxon ship burial at **Sutton Hoo**, Suffolk—filled with marvelously worked artifacts, weapons and

treasures—is believed to have once contained the body of an **Anglo Saxon king**. One of the last burials of this type in England, the artifacts comprise a fusion of Christian and non-Christian elements, suggesting transition as **Christianity** gained in popularity and strength.



KEY

→ Xuanzang's route

The travels of Xuanzang

The young monk left the Tang capital, Chang'an, in around 630. He crossed Central Asia and reached India in 645.

affiliation—those recruited for fighting were made dependents of tribal members; and a taxation system that favored Muslims and encouraged conversion but allowed Christians and Jews to follow their religions.

Buddhism became increasingly influential in Tang China; the Buddhist monk **Xuanzang** journeyed far and wide in search of wisdom. His travels became legendary and foresaw the increasing mobility of people and ideas along the **Silk Road**, made possible by the power of the Tang and later the caliphate. Also traveling the Silk Road, **Nestorian Christians** reached **China** from Persia in 635.

ISLAMIC EXPANSION CONTINUED

as the Arabs defeated the Persian counterattack at the Battle of Nihavand in 642, **dealing the final blow to the Sasanian Empire**; the last emperor, Yazdgird III, died in 651, and with him died Zoroastrianism, the religion of the empire. Conversion of the population to **Islam** proceeded slowly but steadily over the following centuries. The Arabs met with similar success in Egypt where the Byzantines offered only token resistance. The **fall of Alexandria** came in 642, the same year that the Muslims founded the military settlement of Fustat, which later became Cairo. The following year the marauding Islamic armies conquered Tripolitania in North Africa as their advance continued,

637 Battle of Qadisiyya: Arab forces defeat Persians and conquer Persia as far north as Mosul

c. 641 Sutton Hoo burial

639 Death of Dagobert, last of the strong Merovingian kings

641 Death of Heraclius

642 End of Sasanian Empire; Persians crushed at Battle of Nihavand

642 Death of Oswald of Northumbria

644 Caliph Umar assassinated; Uthman promulgates Qu'ran to be written down

645 Xuanzang returns to China after pan Asia travels

646 Taika reforms in Japan

647 Death of Indian emperor Harsha; his empire breaks up

649 Death of Tang emperor Taizong and rise of Empress Wu